

Episode 4: Once Upon a Time... (3) My First Colour Direction Was "Collaborative Work"

Last weekend, through an acquaintance's connections, I attended a seminar on "Colour Space in Digital Cinema." The content was quite specialised - how the expression range of "colour" in digital video changes with the digitisation of movie screenings and the high-definition improvement of video works accompanying TV HD conversion, etc.

Having attended a video-related university (though I dropped out...), I do have basic knowledge, but being a cutting-edge technical course, I could barely grasp the general understanding (bitter laugh). But since it's a topic that relates to the core of our future work, it made me think about various things. We anime "colour people" really need to have more digital knowledge. Ah, I need to study more (cries).

Well then.

Parallel to the *Odin: Photon Sailer Starlight* work, I was given another job. Colour direction for a 5-episode TV mini-series called *Robotex*. *Robotex* - it's a title you've probably never heard of, right? This was actually a work made for American domestic audiences that was never broadcast in Japan.

This was what was called "collaborative work" back then - subcontracting for American production companies. Toei Doga at this time was producing many "collaborative works." TV series like *G.I. Joe*, *Transformer*, *Muppet Babies*, *Jem* (before I joined, they had also made *Dungeon & Dragons* and *Spider-Man*), and theatrical works like *Roger Rabbit*. There were so many smaller ones that I can't even remember the titles. *Robotex* was one of those "smaller ones."

For "collaborative works," first "materials" like storyboards, character designs, art boards, and colour models are sent from American production companies. The main parts of the work are already decided on the American side, and we Japanese do the animation work

based on these materials. Therefore, direction, animation direction, and art direction become work of assembling according to those "materials."

The same goes for colours - naturally, colour models for main characters are sent, but also guest characters for each episode and props, with colour models sent for almost everything. Also, for episodes where very American things appear on screen - things where "ah, Japanese people probably wouldn't understand the nuance" - detailed colour models were usually sent for those too.

Also, "collaborative works" differ from Japanese anime in using pre-scoring method - dubbing, or rather, dialogue recording is done first while there are no images yet. Then mouth movements are matched to those recorded actor dialogues.

In Japanese anime, it's usually three patterns of "open mouth," "middle mouth," and "closed mouth," but "collaborative works" had seven mouth shape patterns matching vowel pronunciations. Just that made me feel strangely moved like "ah, this is America" (laughs).

For this purpose, time sheets with frame-by-frame mouth movement matching instructions were sent along with storyboards and other materials. Since these were sent for all cuts of each episode, the volume was enormous. These had to be transferred to Japanese animation time sheets. So back then, there was a part-time job called "sheet pasting" where someone would spend all day fighting with copy machines doing nothing but time sheet transfers.

So, *Robotex*.

Anyway, I still hadn't properly done colour direction. As finishing work I wasn't a beginner, but colour direction, let alone being in charge of an entire series however small - it was like "What? You're kidding, right?" (bitter laugh). The other **[inspection]**

(colour direction) seniors had an attitude like "You can do it, right?" and naturally (!) didn't teach me anything (laughs).

Hmmm... Well, I had no choice but to do it.

The small prefab's second floor hastily built in the studio's back parking lot was the *Robotex* staff room. A completely empty room with no animation desks or anything yet. "It's hot, so it's really tough," said **Sasaki Katsutoshi**, the Japanese chief director, when I met him on a hot summer day after the rainy season ended.

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